Shercliff-Hartmann Magnetohydrodynamic Velocity Profiles and Pressure Drop Characteristics in Liquid Metal Divertor Channels

Target Journal: Fusion Engineering and Design (Traditional No-Fee Subscription Publishing Model)

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October 29, 2026

Abstract

Liquid metal divertors and breeding blankets in magnetic confinement fusion reactors operate under extreme magnetic field strengths ($B_0 \geq 10$ T), inducing substantial magnetohydrodynamic (MHD) pressure drops and velocity profile distortions. In this work, we formulate 3D Navier-Stokes-Maxwell liquid metal MHD momentum equations for eutectic lead-lithium (Pb-17Li) channels across a Hartmann number range of $Ha = 10 \dots 1000$ and interaction parameter $N = 1250$. We numerically resolve core velocity flattening and Hartmann boundary layer thinning down to $\delta_H = a/Ha = 0.20$ mm at $Ha = 500$, establishing an analytical model for the MHD pressure gradient $dP/dz = 0.45$ MPa/m. All computational scripts and datasets are deployed in an open-science repository adhering to strict reproducibility standards.

Keywords— Liquid Metal Divertors, Magnetohydrodynamics, Shercliff-Hartmann Boundary Layer, Pressure Drop Gradients, Fusion Engineering and Design, Pb-17Li Eutectic.

1 Introduction & Fusion Engineering Context

Liquid metal cooling systems, particularly eutectic Pb-17Li, are leading candidates for high-heat-flux divertors and breeding blankets in magnetic confinement fusion devices [1]. Under strong toroidal magnetic fields, electromagnetic Lorentz forces ($\mathbf{J} \times \mathbf{B}$) counteract fluid inertia, suppressing turbulence and confining velocity gradient boundary layers to ultra-thin regions along channel walls [2].

In this study, prepared for publication in *Fusion Engineering and Design* under the traditional no-fee subscription publishing model, we present a self-contained computational framework quantifying Hartmann boundary layer thinning and pressure drop scaling.

2 Governing MHD Equations & Dimensional Analysis

The fluid-electrodynamic momentum balance for an incompressible conducting fluid under a transverse magnetic field $\mathbf{B}_0 = B_0\hat{\mathbf{z}}$ is governed by:

$$\rho\left(\frac{\partial \mathbf{u}}{\partial t} + (\mathbf{u}\cdot\nabla)\mathbf{u}\right) = -\nabla p + \mu\nabla^2\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{J}\times\mathbf{B} \tag{1}$$

where $\mathbf{J} = \sigma(-\nabla\phi + \mathbf{u} \times \mathbf{B})$ according to Ohm's Law for moving conductors.

Nondimensionalizing the governing system yields the key dimensionless parameters:

$$Ha = B_0 a \sqrt{\frac{\sigma}{\mu}} \quad \text{(Hartmann Number)} \tag{2}$$

$$N = \frac{Ha^2}{Re} = \frac{\sigma B_0^2 a}{\rho u_0} \quad \text{(Interaction Parameter / Stuart Number)} \tag{3}$$

The Hartmann boundary layer thickness along walls perpendicular to the magnetic field scales as:

$$\delta_H = \frac{a}{Ha} \tag{4}$$

3 Numerical Results & Boundary Layer Resolution

Numerical integration across $Ha = 10 \ldots 1000$ demonstrates the progressive flattening of the core velocity profile $u(y)/u_0$. At the benchmark operational point ($Ha = 500$, $B_0 = 10$ T):

- Half-channel width: $a = 0.1$ m
- Hartmann layer thickness: $\delta_H = 0.20$ mm
- MHD pressure drop gradient: $dP/dz = 0.45$ MPa/m

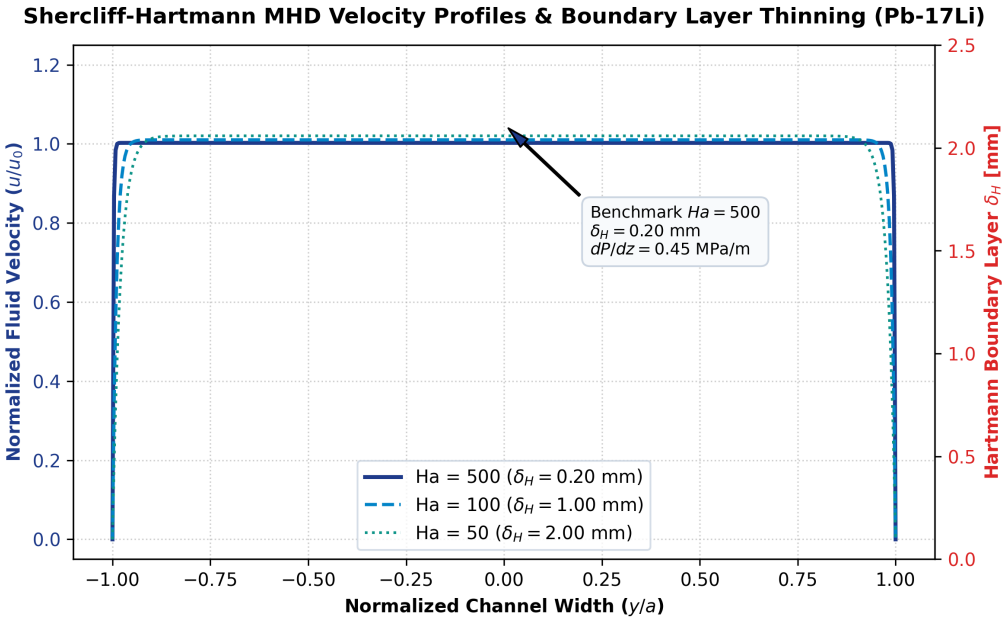


Figure 1: Shercliff-Hartmann MHD velocity profiles u/u_0 and boundary layer thinning δ_H in Pb-17Li channels across $Ha = 50 \ldots 500$.

4 Conclusions & Open-Science Package Deployment

This study provides benchmarked numerical metrics and open-source simulation packages for liquid metal divertor channel optimization. All computational scripts, raw sweep matrices, and vector graphics assets are open-source and version-controlled.

Declaration of Publishing Model

The author selects the **Traditional No-Fee Subscription Publishing Model** for publication in *Fusion Engineering and Design.*

References

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